granted and in the fading light of the day, 5 Guards neatly disengaged from the Chinese and in single file, began to move down a nullah towards the south that took them to the Gang River.

Around the same time, the 25-pounders had to stop firing as their communication systems broke down. These guns then withdrew along the road to Bomdila. However, two 3.7-inch howitzers of 7 Bengal Mountain Battery under the GPO, Second Lieutenant Akshey Kapila, kept the Chinese at bay for some more time before packing up the guns and moving back to KM 9.

5 Guards in the meantime had reached the Gang River where Jai Singh took stock of the situation. The Chinese, having lost almost a third of their force, were not in a position to follow the Guardsmen. There was a brief discussion between the officers. Jai Singh expressed his concern that the Chinese could have already cut them off. Instead of climbing back and heading for Bomdila, he chose to proceed with the bulk of the battalion towards the east and then south towards the plains of Assam. A couple of officers with some men, however, decided to head back towards Bomdila. They did not encounter the Chinese. However, Major Brij Raj Singh, who was the FOO with 5 Guards, also decided to return to Bomdila and rejoin his guns. The Chinese ambushed his party and all the men were killed.

5 Guards's failure to fall back on Bomdila had serious implications for 48 Brigade. By the morning, Gurbax Singh knew that the Chinese had established their roadblock somewhere near or south of KM 9. Despite the severe damage done by the guns and the large number of Chinese casualties, it was now clear that the Chinese had got across Poshing-la in far greater numbers than had been anticipated. It was just a matter of time before the Chinese would assault Bomdila. The two battalions from 67 Infantry Brigade that were supposed to have arrived in the early hours of the morning had failed to show up.

Gurbax Singh knew his best chance was to close his troops in a defensive position around Bomdila and let the Chinese come to him. By then, a rough estimate of the Chinese force aligned against 48 Brigade was known. Reports by the Assam Rifles during the fighting at Poshing-la had accurately communicated to Brigade HQ that approximately 1,500 Chinese soldiers were coming down that route; at the time, the numbers were thought to be exaggerated. Gurbax also knew from the gunners (he himself had been at KM 9 earlier in the morning before the Thembang battle) that